## *32.1 The Nizari*

One of Sabbah's political strategies had been the strategic murder, carried out by young devotees of the Nizari cause called *fidaiyan* (singular *fidawi*), of prominent Turkish leaders. The *fidaiyan*, not afraid to sacrifice their lives on their missions, were often successful, and increasingly feared; so much so that almost every twelfth-century assassination was chalked up to them by their Turkish and Sunni Muslim enemies. It was, in fact, hostile Sunni historians who first suggested that the *fidaiyan* were drugged with hashish into willingness to carry out their suicide missions. *Hashishin* became a derogatory Sunni term for the *fidaiyan* (who probably used no hashish at all); Crusader accounts picked up the term and Latinized it into *Assassin*; and thus the English language gained a new word for political killings, *assassination*.[4]

Muhammad Ghuri had mounted at least one campaign against the mountain state of the Nizari, and it is certainly possible that a *fidawi* was dispatched to remove him. But other accounts credit the Ghurid king's death to an attack of conquered and resentful Khokars from the Punjab, or perhaps the machinations of one of his own officials. Whoever carried it out, Muhammad's death brought an immediate end to the adolescent Ghurid empire. Within months, the whole huge expanse had fallen apart again under Ghuri's rivaling successors. His nephew claimed the western territories as an independent king, and three of his Turkish slaves turned governors did the same over their own lands: one in Ghazni, a second in the Sind, and a third, Qutb-ud-din, in Lahore.

Qutb-ud-din outshone them all. He declared himself sultan of the north Indian lands, and although he ruled for only four years before dying in a fall from his polo pony in 1210, his sultanate lasted for over three centuries. The four years of Qutb-ud-din's rule, after all, had built on the previous twenty years of his service to the Ghurids in northern India; and during those decades, he had worked hard to help the two Ghuri brothers transform their realm into a Muslim land. In his hands, it became a particularly *Indian* Muslim land: free from domination that came from beyond the mountains, but also a land where the old religious traditions were firmly stamped down into the mud. "He purged by his sword the land of Hind from the filth of infidelity and vice," writes his contemporary, the Persian historian Hasan Nizami, "and freed the whole of that country from the thorn of God-plurality, and the impurity of idol-worship, and by his royal vigour and intrepidity, left not one temple standing."[5]

At his death, Qutb-ud-din's son Aram Shah set himself up as the next ruler of the north Indian kingdom. At once, he lost the southern cities of